EXTENDED ESSAY

The role and perception of women in Disney movies:

To what extent do the Disney movies "Cinderella" and "Beauty and the Beast" show the change of perception of women from different time periods?

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Introduction

Disney has produced many popular fairy tale movies for children. Some of the best known are "Cinderella" and "Beauty and the Beast". They are magical and fascinating, so obviously, young children look up to examples from those fairy tales and learn certain behaviours. Although those are just children's movies, they present certain values. They demonstrate gender roles and expectations, even if that is not their primary purpose. Since "Cinderella" was produced in 1950 and "Beauty and the Beast" in 1990, there are quite a lot of differences between these two movies. During those 40 years, there were a lot of important events that changed women's role and position in society; hence, they might present different values. I believe that based on these two movies, one can see a change in the role of women in society. I think it is important to also mention that those two stories are very old and have hundreds of versions. Many elements from their original version were removed or replaced in the Disney version. Hence, I believe that their original version is not as important as the movies, which are a good representation of the years when they were produced.

Cultural context

The concept of a housewife and the traditional perfect family is widely known, and nothing new. The gender roles in the 1950s were quite straightforward and Jennifer Holt summed up the expectations from women quite well in "The Ideal Woman": "*Women were considered domestic caregivers, with sole responsibility for the home and child-rearing, while men "brought home the bacon.""*[1]. She also mentioned the book Courtney and Lockeretz which

[1] Holt, Jennifer. "The Ideal Woman". *Csustan.Edu*, 2022, https://www.csustan.edu/sites/default/files/honors/documents/journals/soundings/Holt.pdf.

presented four stereotypes of the “ideal” woman shown in magazine advertisements, to which I will refer later in my essay. The growth of women’s labour participation rate from 35% in 1950 to 58% in 1990[2] is important to mention, as it shows a change in their daily tasks. Furthermore, in 1950, less than 30% of survey respondents approved of a working wife, while in 1990 it was 80%[3]. This shows how much society’s attitude and mentality changed in those 40 years. The year 1950 was after the first wave of feminism, which "*had a fairly simple goal: have society recognize women are humans, not property"*[4] 1990, on the other hand, was going through the third wave when women "*were able to think about other aspects of their identity, welcoming individually a rebellion"*[5]. The concept of being the “ideal” woman and housewife had and still has an impact on the identity of women. Fulfilling the traditional, feminine gender roles is still very often expected from women, but with the addition of also fulfilling career goals. Although there were big shifts in attitudes, the ideals are still quite similar.

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[2] United States, Congress, Toossi , Mitra, and Teresa L Morisi. *Women in the Workforce before, during, and after the Great Recession*, July 2017.
[3] "What Percentage Of The US Public Approves Of Working Wives?". Our World In Data, 2017, https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/what-percentage-of-the-us-public-approves-of-working-wives.
[4] Soken-Huberty, Emmaline. “Types of Feminism: The Four Waves.” *Human Rights Careers*, 24 Apr. 2022, https://www.humanrightscareers.com/issues/types-of-feminism-the-four-waves/.
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The example of “Cinderella”

Cinderella is a beautiful girl who is resented by her stepmother and stepsisters for her beauty, which is mentioned by the narrator in the first few minutes: "*bitterly jealous of Cinderella’s charm and beauty"* She does chores for them and is treated more like a maid or slave than a sister. There is a huge contrast between Cinderella, who was "*gentle and kind*" and her stepsisters and stepmother, who were described as *"cold", "cruel", "selfish"* or *"vain"*. She was a pushover but kept being nice to them. It sends the message that instead of fighting and standing up for yourself, you should be nice to people who treat you horribly.

"No matter how your heart is grieving,"

If you keep on believing

"The dream you wish for will come true."

The opening song, *"A Dream Is a Wish Your Heart Makes,*" is about believing in dreams because one day they might come true. It presents Cinderella as having a passive character and being strongly dependent on others. Believing in dreams is not anything bad; however, all she did was believe in them and wait for them to come true. I think it shows the expectations of what a woman’s character should be in the 1950s. She is shown as fully dependent on others' decisions and feelings about her. Her beauty was the only thing that got her out of her house, and marrying a prince was the only solution to her situation. She never tried to stand up against her abuse or do something for herself. It sends a message that submissive women will be rewarded as long as they do what they are asked for. They should just do their duties and wait for the rescue.

The song also undervalues the abuse she endured every day and insists she should just hope for things to get better. And although it is presented as a bad thing, it makes sense why she did not

do anything as she would receive no help. However, Cinderella is praised for remaining *"gentle and kind*" even though she was experiencing abuse every day. She is praised for her attitude. She should not have to be nice to people who use her every day but should speak up for herself. But instead of fighting for herself, all she does is wait, because she can not do much. It shows the situation of women in the 1950s who experienced abuse but could not get help as there were little or no options available.

Her singing and daydreaming throughout the whole movie also present her as naive and childish because of her daydreaming nature. It emphasizes her female weakness and makes her appear unprofessional and immature.

The attitude of men towards women is quite clearly visible here. The men in the story see women as either wives or mothers. They do not talk about Cinderella or any other woman in anything other than those two roles. The main purpose of the ball was to find the most beautiful one, thereby making her suitable for having children with the prince. The King said, *"And see that every eligible maid is there"* which further shows the way he thought about women. In "The 1950s and the 1960s and the American Woman: the Transition from the "Housewife" to the Feminist," Vanessa Martins Lamb mentions that "*They were "the wife," "the mother," and "the housewife," and their own identities were a reminiscence of the past, of a time when they knew who they were and what they wanted in life: a family, a "perfect" family."*[6] This shows that the men in the movie represented the way women were viewed in the 1950s. They had no other identity than being a wife or mother, losing their individuality.

[6] Lamb, Vanessa. "The 1950S And The 1960S And The American Woman: The Transition From The ”Housewife” To The Feminist””. *Dumas.Ccsd.Cnrs.Fr*, 2011, https://dumas.ccsd.cnrs.fr/dumas-00680821/document.

The prince did not seem to remember how Cinderella looked, so he had to send her shoe for every woman to try on. The glass shoe is supposed to have the symbolic meaning of purity and true identity. It makes sense, and it has a nice meaning; however, the prince would not need a shoe if he actually remembered Cinderella. He showed no real effort to look for her by having Duke do it for him—*"The Grand Duke. He has been hunting all night."* He knew that with his position he wouldn't be refused the marriage, so he did not need to put in that much effort. *"The prince, the sire, swears he'll marry none, but the girl who fits this slipper"* further shows the truth of this statement. Cinderella dreamed about love, and as mentioned by Lamb in the 1950s, *"Marriage was an incredibly powerful institution during these years; people did not ask themselves if they were going to get married, but when and to whom?"*[7] She surely would not say no to a prince, as it was not just expected of her but also her only chance for freedom.

The appearance and beauty of Cinderella play a crucial role in the whole story. Her stepmother saw a danger in Cinderella for her daughters since she was so beautiful. Since marrying a good man was basically the main purpose of a woman's life in the story, she was a threat to her stepsisters - *"*she *was grimly determined to forward the interests of her own two awkward daughters".* If it was not for a prince finding her beautiful and falling in love with her, she would still be stuck in the house. She was not judged by her other qualities. Her talents, mind, or skills did not matter; it was only her look that was valuable in that case. It shows what matters most to make a "suitable mother" worthy of attention. It is objectifying women, and it shows the importance of women's beauty in the 1950s as the most important quality.

[7] Lamb, Vanessa. "The 1950S And The 1960S And The American Woman: The Transition From The "Housewife" To The Feminist"". *Dumas.Ccsd.Cnrs.Fr*, 2011, https://dumas.ccsd.cnrs.fr/dumas-00680821/document.

While the mice were making a dress for Cinderella, one mouse said, *"Leave the sewing to the women."* The typical gender roles were shown even when dividing work between mice. It is the most direct demonstration of gender stereotypes in the movie, where even mice present them. The division of gender roles even among animals underscores their relevance.

Cinderella also fits perfectly into the earlier mentioned four stereotypes listed in "The Ideal Woman" by Jennifer Holt[8] based on the research by Courtney and Lockeretz. The first one is that *"a woman's place is in the home with her family".* "Cinderella" presents the main woman's role as marrying and having children. It was not only how men perceived women, but also how women imagined marriage. The next one is "*Women do not make important decisions*" Although it refers to bigger purchases, I think it could refer to a wider context. She did not make any decisions for herself; even marriage was pretty much already decided for her. The third one talks about *"women as dependent on and in need of a man's protection and acceptance"* which again, was seen in the story. Cinderella had to be rescued by the prince and was dependent on him. Holt sums the list with *"men regard women primarily as sexual objects and thus of a lower status"* It is more difficult to show in the story since it is a movie directed toward children. However, I think that the importance of beauty in the story could fit quite well, especially as it is seen as the most desirable trait and quality.

The movie shows that women are submissive, passive, and only dream about marriage. It is a fairly accurate depiction of what an ideal woman should be in the 1950s, which is why Cinderella is presented in this manner. It further shows what the expectations and roles of women were back then. And to close that list, it also presents the fact that it was quite impossible

[8] Holt, Jennifer. "The Ideal Woman". *Csustan.Edu*, 2022, https://www.csustan.edu/sites/default/files/honors/documents/journals/soundings/Holt.pdf.

to escape or fight domestic abuse in the 1950s. I think it shows the gender roles in the 1950s quite well.

The example of "Beauty and The Beast"

Belle is described as "*a smart, plucky woman"* Her appearance is praised several times throughout the movie to underscore her beauty. In the opening scene, she is described as *"the most beautiful girl in town"* and *"her looks have got no parallel*" by the residents of the city. Everyone admires her for her looks but finds her strange for reading. She is called *"funny", "peculiar"* and *"strange".* Belle's love of reading represents education and demonstrates her intelligence and education. It presents a change in society regarding women's education and independence.

Although the story is supposed to be about looking past the exterior appearance, there is a big emphasis on it anyway. In the prologue, the prince refuses to help an old beggar woman who is looking for *"shelter from the bitter cold"* because of her *"haggard appearance"* The moral of this short story was to look past the physical appearance and find inner beauty in people. The story suggests that he would have helped if only the woman had been beautiful. It is the first, but not the only, moment when a woman's appearance is crucial. It does make sense to put a "lesson" like that in the beginning, since it tells the viewer to look past the beast's appearance and focus on his "inner beauty". On the other hand, Beast wasn't the one who had to look past it and find the inner beauty. It refutes the whole moral, as Beast did not even learn his lesson. Further in the story, we can see the proof of Beast again focusing on appearance. He imprisoned Belle's father in a cold, dark cell, even though he was sick. When Belle switched with him, she received a nice room and was allowed to move around the castle. However, he was also under

the influence of his servants, who were using Belle to turn them all back into human form. It is significant to the point because it demonstrates the importance of appearance and that being nice to women is solely for their benefit.

In the first song in the movie, she sings, *"There must be more than this provincial life".* Later, her father promises her that *"we'll get out of this town and travel to all those places you've read about in your book*". In another scene, she sings again:

"I want much more than this provincial life."

I'm looking for adventure in the great wide open somewhere.

I want it more than I can tell.

And for once, it might be grand.

To have someone understand

"I want so much more than they've got planned."

This song shows the change from dreaming only about love to wanting more than being a housewife. It is important since it presents the change from the most popular role of a woman as a stay-at-home wife in the 1950s to wanting independence in the 1990s. It is quite a big change in mindset, and the movie reflects that change in society.

Belle wants independence and adventures. Not only that, but she also needs someone to understand her and her dreams. It is strongly emphasized with *"I want it more than I can tell"* and using the phrase *"much more",* it shows how much she wants it. She is also presented as a strong heroine by not only trying to save her father but also sacrificing herself for him. This is

a crucial message of the story, and it shows her as a powerful person instead of the passive woman of the 1950s.

Although Belle started by dreaming about adventures and independence, it was all invalidated further in the story where her dream is presented as a *"childhood dream*" which reduces its value and seriousness, as if it were something you grow out of. On one hand, it is vital to focus on real life, but it shouldn't be at the cost of giving up her biggest dream and goal. It shows that it is completely fine and actually good to give up your dreams for another person instead of sharing them. As the independent protagonist that she was supposed to be, she settles down, just like a proper lady should. Her happy ending is marrying the prince and leaving her dreams behind. Although it showed that a woman might want more than just settling down, it is left behind further in the story, returning to the 1950s vision of happy marriage. It shows the progress, but it is still visible what the priority should be.

The story also shows how women's concerns were often minimised and downplayed. It is most visible in the scene where Belle refuses to accompany Beast to dinner. He *"storms to Belle's room"* and starts ordering her to join him for dinner. When she refused, he threatened her, saying *"I will drag you by the hair"* and "*Then starve"* All the words used have aggressive and negative connotations. Instead of reflecting on his own bad behaviour, he wonders why she is being so difficult and what she wants him to do. He keeps pitying himself and going as far as violating her privacy. He is presented as someone who was deeply hurt and misunderstood. He repeats his aggressive behaviour again when he *"grabs her arm and pulls off her sleeve as she falls backward*" He is then presented as a victim once more: *"I'm sorry! I'm sorry! I did not mean to frighten you. I did not mean to hurt you. You do not understand. There's so little of me left... so little of me".* Ellipsis shows that he is very hurt and upset, and the words used in the song *"If I can't love her"* are just highlighting it: "*tortured shape", "my dream dies", "helpless", "cold" and "lost illusion*"

Beast is constantly portrayed as deeply hurt and a victim, making Belle appear to be the bad one for rejecting him. Not only does it show victim-blaming but also an example of a male batter who, according to an article by Edin, Lalos, Högberg, and Dahlgren in Sweden *"tends to diminish what has happened, seems not to fully understand the consequences of their violent behavior, and is thus able to justify themselves and even portray themselves as victims"*[9] He fits that description perfectly. There is little improvement visible when it comes to the behaviour and attitude of men towards women in both stories. It demonstrates that, despite the fact that the stories were written over a 40-year period, the justification for men's bad behaviour did not change. They can still do quite a lot of questionable and wrong things and won't be punished for them. However, she can stand up for herself, and Beast's servants knew it wasn't the right approach. This shows that there is more awareness, and they know it is wrong, even if it is to some degree ignored

Belle's actions are ridiculed, and all fault is put on her. She is the one to blame for being *"difficult"* even though he imprisoned her and had just harassed her. It diminishes the beast's fault and Belle's suffering. It is her fault for hurting Beast's feelings, and she is pushed by his servants to accept his *"temper"*. It shows something similar to how women are often blamed for being in an abusive relationship and *"pushing"* their partner to be aggressive, even though they are victims. Their concerns and refusals are often ignored, and they are ridiculed for their choices. They should just *"get over themselves"* and do what they're asked to avoid an argument. It is an example of victim blaming that is still relevant today.

[9] Edin, Kerstin E. et al. "Violent Men". *Journal Of Interpersonal Violence*, vol 23, no. 2, 2008, pp. 225-244. *SAGE Publications*, https://doi.org/10.1177/0886260507309342.

Women being nice to men, even when they should not be, carries throughout the whole movie. Another example is the interaction between Belle and Gaston. Instead of saying no, she gives him polite refusal answers that omit that. Even after he asked her to marry her, she said *"I just do not deserve you",* making it look as if she was the problem so he would leave her alone. In reality, he was a pushy man who kept harassing her. To not hurt his pride, she avoided the direct answer and made it her fault. Even after that, he refused to accept it and assumed she was *"always playing hard to get".* It shows how little her opinion mattered in that case. For the most part, the entire interaction is presented as a joke and something to laugh at which is quite problematic. It also indicates that women should be kind and polite, even when a man is harassing them. The breaking point was when he kissed her, and she finally stood up for herself. It is significant to the whole point because it shows that she is still polite, but she can fight for herself when her boundaries are crossed. It shows an improvement for sure, even if it is not perfect yet.

Comparison of the two movies

In both Belle's and Cinderella's cases, their beauty was what both helped and harmed them. Because of Cinderella's beauty, her stepmother and stepsister hated her and abused her, but it was also a reason why the prince fell in love with her, hence saving her from them marrying her. In Belle's case, it brought her unwanted attention from Gaston but also gave her privileges in Beast's castle. Both of the stories are strongly impacted by the appearance of the main characters, which shows that beauty is an important quality, no matter if it is 1950 or 1990.

Belle and Cinderella are very different when it comes to character. Bella is a much more independent and active character, while Cinderella is more passive and boring. Belle is shown

as a strong and well-read person, dreaming of adventures and discovering the world. She also has more identity and individuality than Cinderella. However, it feels as if the society around them sees women mostly as mother-wife material and not as individual people. Even though Belle liked reading, others found it weird. It again shows an improvement in the goals and behaviour of women, but it proves that society still puts a lot of pressure on women and their role as caregivers.

In both movies, men are far from perfect; however, the way they see the main character also changes. In "Cinderella" there is mostly focus on her role and future as a mother and wife, while in "Beauty and the Beast," the Beast sees Belle as more than just that. He is able to see her intelligence and other qualities. It is important because it shows that a woman's value became more than just the ability to have children and cook. It is also worth mentioning that while in "Cinderella," the chores and duties that women are supposed to do are stated very clearly (the mice making a dress, for example), in "Beauty and the Beast," Belle does much more things, some of which could be considered manly, like helping her father build the thing.

Although it might seem like Beauty and the Beast is more modern and progressive based on the examples above, I think that's where it ends. It is actually very similar to Cinderella in a lot of ways. Even though Belle does more and is seen as doing more, both of those movies still present women in the same way, and a woman's role is summed up as acting ladylike and marriage. She left her dreams behind to marry Beast, and the town's residents saw her as weird. They show similar qualities that women should have, though they are not always good. They present the main characters in a similarly naive and dreamy way. They also present how women should be nice and polite, no matter how they are treated by the other person. They only find true happiness when a man shows up, saves them, and they fall in love.

They both also ended the same way, with marriage to a prince charming. I find it disappointing to create an independent, strong character like Belle only to make her fall so deeply in love with a man that she gives up her dreams. On the other hand, it can be viewed as character growth and maturing, and she actually did stand up for herself and fight. She also has her own identity and personality, and is seen as more than just a wife.

Conclusion

I think both movies show a change in gender roles and perceptions of women quite well. In the movie "Cinderella" the ideal image of a woman and how she should behave, but also women's struggles in 1950s society, are presented very clearly. From Cinderella's behaviour, one can tell that in the 1950s, a woman should be passive, obedient, dependent on a man, marry, and do household chores. But it also shows how difficult it was to get out of an abusive situation back then. In contrast, Belle shows that women can be independent, strong, well-educated, and have some passions. She can also stand up for herself and say "no" even if it is not always respected. It shows the improvements and progress that society has made. However, it is also clear that it is far from perfect and there are a lot of stereotypical gender roles.

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